Students Studying in The United States

INTERNATIONAL TRAVEL

BEFORE YOU TRAVEL

Before traveling abroad, make sure you have the proper documentation to re-enter the U.S. including a valid travel signature. Save the emergency contact numbers below to your phone before you travel.

1. **Consider the duration of your travel**
   - Students are expected to remain in the U.S. and participate in their academic activities in person for the duration of every required term.
   - OGS can't authorize remote study from outside the U.S. and can't give permission for travel during a required academic term.
   - F-1 Students who are outside of the U.S. for more than 5-months between academic terms* will be required to request a new Initial I-20 (this will reset your eligibility for employment authorization)

- *The 5-month rule does not apply to students pursuing approved study abroad, global co-op, or graduate research abroad.

2. **Review current travel recommendations**
   - Read OGS's Current Travel Recommendations (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/current-travel-recommendations/)
   - Read GSOC's Travel Updates and Announcements (https://globalsafety.northeastern.edu/travel-updates-and-announcements/)

3. **Get a valid travel signature**
   - Your I-20 or DS-2019 must have a travel signature (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/forms-and-guides/travel-signature-request/) valid for the date you re-enter the U.S. Learn more below.
     - Current students require a new travel signature every 12 months and alumni on OPT/STEM/AT require a new travel signature every 6 months.

4. **Check the validity of your visa**
   - If your visa will expire before your return, you will need to renew it in your home country/country of residency (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/current-students/traveling/renewing-your-visa/) before re-entering the U.S.

5. **Register your travel**
   - Register with the university's Travel Registry (https://globalsafety.northeastern.edu/travel-registry/). This helps the Global Safety Operations Center assist you quickly in an emergency.

6. **Gather your required documents**
   - Pack your documents in carry-on luggage for easy access. See the full document checklist below.

REQUIRED DOCUMENTS TO RE-ENTER THE U.S.

+ Current F-1/J-1 Students

+ F-1 Students on Post-OPT or STEM OPT Extension and J-1 students on Post-AT

WHAT IS A TRAVEL SIGNATURE?

A travel signature is an endorsement on your I-20 or DS 2019, given by a Designated School Official (DSO) or Alternative Responsible Officer (ARO), after screening your immigration record and academic enrollment to verify that you have been successfully maintaining status.

Where to find it?

- F-1 students: Bottom of page 2 of your current I-20
- J-1 exchange visitors: Bottom right of your DS-2019

How long is my travel signature valid?

- Current F/J students: 12 months
- Alumni on OPT/STEM/AT: 6 months

OGS holds in-person travel signature sessions before major vacation periods. Check the events page (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/events/) for upcoming dates.

Travel Signature Request » (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/forms-and-guides/travel-

AUTOMATIC REVALIDATION

If you travel to Canada, Mexico, or certain Caribbean islands for less than 30 days, you may be eligible to re-enter the U.S. with an expired F-1/J-1 visa. Please refer to the Department of State website

(https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/visa-information-resources/visa-expiration-date/auto-revalidate.html) for more details prior to traveling.

ARRIVING AT A U.S. PORT OF ENTRY

Please do not use NEXUS or Global Entry, or an automated passport kiosk, to enter the U.S. You must always speak with a Customs and Border Protection (CBP) Officer and present your passport and Forms I-20/DS-2019 in order to be admitted to the U.S. in F/J student status.

+ **Primary Inspection**
+ **Secondary Inspection**
+ **Social Media and Electronic Device Searches**
+ **If you receive a Form I-515 or I-515A**

CHECK YOUR I-94 RECORD

You are advised to check your I-94 and print a copy after every re-entry to the U.S.

Learn more here about obtaining your most recent I-94. (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/new-students/arrival/obtaining-i-94/)

TRAVEL TIPS

- If you have completed OPT, Academic Training (AT), or your academic program, and are in a grace period, you will not be allowed back into the U.S. on your F-1 or J-1 visa.
- Any family members traveling with you who have F-2 or J-2 visas will also need to carry the same documents.

Please review the U.S. Department of Homeland Security (DHS) tips for travel (https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/2013/11/ask-a-dso-how-do-i-prepare-to-return-to-the-united-states-after-a-vacation).

- OGS does not recommend F-1/J-1 students take **extended absences during the academic term**, as this may impact your status.

- If you have received a notice of visa revocation or have ever had a civil or criminal charge (even if it did not lead to an arrest or conviction), consult with an experienced immigration attorney (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/immigration-legal-resources/) before traveling.

EMERGENCY ASSISTANCE WHILE TRAVELING

Save these numbers to your phone before you travel.

- If you are at a U.S. Port of Entry (i.e. airport): +1-617-373-2121

- If you are departing for your Northeastern campus within 24 hours or are already in transit: +1-857-214-5332

KEY RESOURCES

Travel Signature Request » (https://myogs.northeastern.edu/istart/controllers/client/ClientEngine.cf serviceid=EFormTravelsignaturerequest0ServiceProvider#_ga=2.213618 1559522075.1564500084)

This is to request a travel endorsement on your I-20 or DS-2019.

RELATED ARTICLES:

U.S. Immigration Legal Resources (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/forms-and-guides/u-s-immigration-legal-resources/)

Renewing your F-1/J-1 Visa (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/current-students/traveling/renewing-your-visa/)

CONTACT OGS

354 Richards Hall
360 Huntington Avenue
Boston, MA 02115
+1-617-373-2310
OGS Service Portal (https://service.northeastern.edu/ogs)

OFFICE HOURS

Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.-5:00p.m.
(Note: We are closed on Tuesdays from 3:00pm – 4:00pm for all staff training and meeting).
Phone Hours:
Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.–4:30p.m. ET

SOCIAL

(https://www.facebook.com/NortheasternOGS/) (https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCrMAnObKFBqnSINJw

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